



126 Is Piracy Good?



130 The Terrible Call



152 Skyping Penelope Cruz

Digital Leisure

Technology Beyond Work

Touched By Tech

Bridging The Gap

At some villages in Andhra Pradesh, illiteracy is no more an impediment in the quest for information

Jyotsna Rege

Much of rural India lives in what can be termed "Media Darkness"—where people do not have access to facilities like television or radio, and in some places, there's no access to newspapers either. Lack of access to information has been one of the impediments to development, and lack of development, in turn, further alienates the rural sector. In a bid to breach this vicious circle, an initiative called Project i-Shakti has used technology to provide information based on

demand, via a network, to villages in the state of Andhra Pradesh.

Where It All Began

Hindustan Lever Limited (HLL) began a programme for rural empowerment called Project Shakti. Project Shakti aims at creating entrepreneurial opportunities in villages all over India so they do not need to rely on agriculture alone for their livelihood. Most of the individuals who have registered with the programme are women, and are called the Shakti entrepreneurs.

"When Unilever developed an interactive dialogue technology,

we considered its purposeful implementation and integration with Project Shakti. Thus was born Project i-Shakti. We decided to begin the venture in AP as the state had already initiated an e-Seva programme, and we tied up with them to launch the services we had conceived under i-Shakti," says Rohit Harirajan, head of the project.

What Is iShakti?

The i-Shakti venture seems simple enough when stated out aloud: it is a kiosk-based interactive dialogue system that contains a computer terminal and offers free

